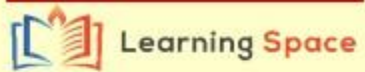


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NEWSPAPER 28th November, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS 48th WEEK



EGYPT & IS ATTACK

UPSC CSE – GS III

GS III... TERRORISM



Learning Space

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

28th NOVEMBER, 2017

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Desert storm

The chaos in the region makes Egypt's counter-terror task even more challenging

The murders, a attack on Friday at a Sufi mosque in the Sinai Peninsula that killed at least 305 people is a grim reminder of the Islamist Egypt's far from a stranger and more fanatical Islamist militancy. Over the past three years, groups operating from the Sinai peninsula, particularly a local arm of the Islamic State, have carried out several terror attacks. The ease with which dozens of militants, carrying the IS's black flags, unleashed the assault on the mosque in Bir al-Abed, surrounding it with vehicles and attacking dozens with hand-held guns, has set them before a new chapter in the bloodiest attack in modern Egypt's history. President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, the general who had captured power through a coup in 2013 promising stability and security, has vowed to respond with "martial law". General Sisi had back similar promises after terrorist strikes in the past, including when a Coptic church in the mainland was bombed by the IS on the Palm Sunday last year, killing at least 45 people. With the Bir al-Abed mosque attack, the terrorists have now raised the stakes and also called into question General Sisi's counter-insurgency strategy.

The IS's strategy in Egypt is similar to that in Syria and Iraq. The group is targeting Christians, who make up about 5% of the Egyptian population, and minority sects within Islam. It makes no secret of its plan to deepen the sectarian division in societies and then exploit these divisions to win over hardline Sunni segments. Egypt's Sinai, a region historically neglected by Cairo and with a vast terrain of deserts, mountains and long coasts, is an ideal operational base for the IS. For the same reasons, counter-insurgency in the Sinai is a challenging task even for a formidable military force. The Egyptian military has also been under strain in view of regional developments since the fall of Mummaz Qaddafi's regime in Libya in 2011 and the resulting chaos in North Africa. The black market trade in weapons from Qaddafi-era depots has strengthened militant groups, including those in the Sinai. Besides, it is suspected that following the more recent collapse of IS networks in Iraq and Syria, Egyptian Islamists who were fighting in those countries have returned home and joined local networks. This poses a daunting challenge to President Sisi. The battle before Cairo is not just a counter-insurgency mission. It has to defeat the militants and bring the supply of weapons, which has been a challenge given the difficult terrain of the Sinai. For the Egyptian government also needs to take steps to address the long-term grievances of the Sinai's population and deny militants local sympathy or support.

1 Desert storm

The chaos in the region makes Egypt's counter-terror task even more challenging

The murderous attack on Friday at a Sufi mosque in the Sinai Peninsula that killed at least 305 people is a grim reminder of the threats Egypt faces from a stronger and more brutish Islamist militancy. Over the past three years, groups operating from the Sinai peninsula, particularly a local arm of the Islamic State, have carried out several terror attacks. The ease with which dozens of militants, carrying the IS's black flags, unleashed the assault on the mosque in Bir al-Abed, surrounding it with vehicles and attacking devotees with bombs and guns, has set alarm bells ringing in Cairo. This is the bloodiest attack in modern Egypt's history. President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, the general who had captured power through a coup in 2013 promising stability and security, has vowed to respond with "brutal force". General Sisi had made similar promises after terrorist strikes in the past, including when a Coptic church in the mainland was bombed by the IS on the Palm Sunday this year, killing at least 45 people. With the Bir al-Abed mosque attack, the terrorists have now raised the stakes and also called into question General Sisi's counter-insurgency strategy.

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1 Desert storm

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Greece

Ionian Sea

Aegean Sea

Cyprus

Lebanon

SYRIA

IRAQ

SINAI PENINSULA

Suez Canal

Israel

JORDAN

Gulf of Aqaba

LIBYA

EGYPT

SAUDI ARABIA

NEWS REPORT



- Attack on Sinai mosque has killed 305 people including 27 children.
- Attack was carried out by 25 to 30 militants.
- A local Islamic State affiliate is spearheading the insurgency in Sinai Peninsula, where the government forces have battled militants for years.
- Dozens of militants carried IS black flags.
- It is the bloodiest hit attack in modern Egypt's history.
- Millions of Egyptians practice Sufi rituals such as reciting poetry, dancing and singing as means to be closer to God.



HOW TO INFER THIS?

- 1 After the collapse of IS networks in Iraq and Syria, the Islamists, who were fighting in those countries might have returned home and joined the local networks,
- 2 Black market trade in weapons from the time of Muammar Gaddafi's regime in Libya is making the task easier.
- 3 The chaos in adjacent country Libya is another reason.
- 4 The strategy of IS in Egypt is just simple. i.e. it targets Christians (which form 10% of Egyptian population) and minorities within Islam.
- 5 It deepens sectarian divisions in societies and exploit these divisions. This facilitates the winning of hard line Sunni Muslims.
- 6 Sinai Peninsula has got vast terrain of desert mountains and long coast. It became ideal operational base for Islamic State (IS).

Counter insurgency in Sinai is a challenging task even for a formidable military force



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SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



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